Sultana of Streaming



Monika Shergill, *49*
Vice-president, Netflix India

ADVICE TO WOMEN

"Make caring a superpower and help everyone around you succeed. That's when the magic happens"

GUILTY PLEASURES
Indian desserts. Reality shows like *Dubai Bling*, *Bollywood Wives* and *Indian Matchmaking*

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Heading the content slate for one of the biggest markets of OTT giant Netflix

IN JULY 2019, AS MONIKA SHERGILL TOOK the reins of Netflix India, she found herself writing end goals for the streaming service. It included 'Home for – biggest movies, biggest series, biggest theatrical cinema and impactful documentaries'. The programming slate of the OTT giant in the past few years proves how Shergill has gone about achieving this. *RRR* (dubbed in Hindi) was one of the most watched films on the service globally last year; many of 2023's best homegrown series such as *Trial By Fire*, *Kohrra* and *The Railway Men* are all Netflix titles; the docu series *The Hunt for Veerappan* drew much acclaim, and with the recent *The Archies*, the platform has produced its biggest film thus far.

Shergill recognises that Netflix is a premium service, but the mission still is how to "make it more aspirational and relatable". Variety and quality are pivotal, so is inclusivity with a special focus on gender. "One half of the world is women so why shouldn't we be represented equally, especially when telling stories? We wouldn't be doing justice in reflecting the world around us," she says. Shows like *Delhi Crime*, *Mismatched*, *Masaba Masaba*, *Aranyak*, *Scoop* and the upcoming *Heeramandi* highlight how Shergill and her team are putting women front and centre. At Netflix, she adds, women occupy key leadership roles globally, including chief creative officer, product officer and technology officer.

Even as Shergill busies herself with commissioning work and keeping track of content on other services, she cannot help but tune into her first love, journalism. It's what she pursued for five years, being an environment correspondent and producer on *Living on the Edge* (Doordarshan and Star TV), a show that would win a Whitley Award (the Green Oscar). News programmes still draw her interest. She says being informed is important for compelling storytelling and to build authentic worlds for fictional shows. ■

–Suhani Singh